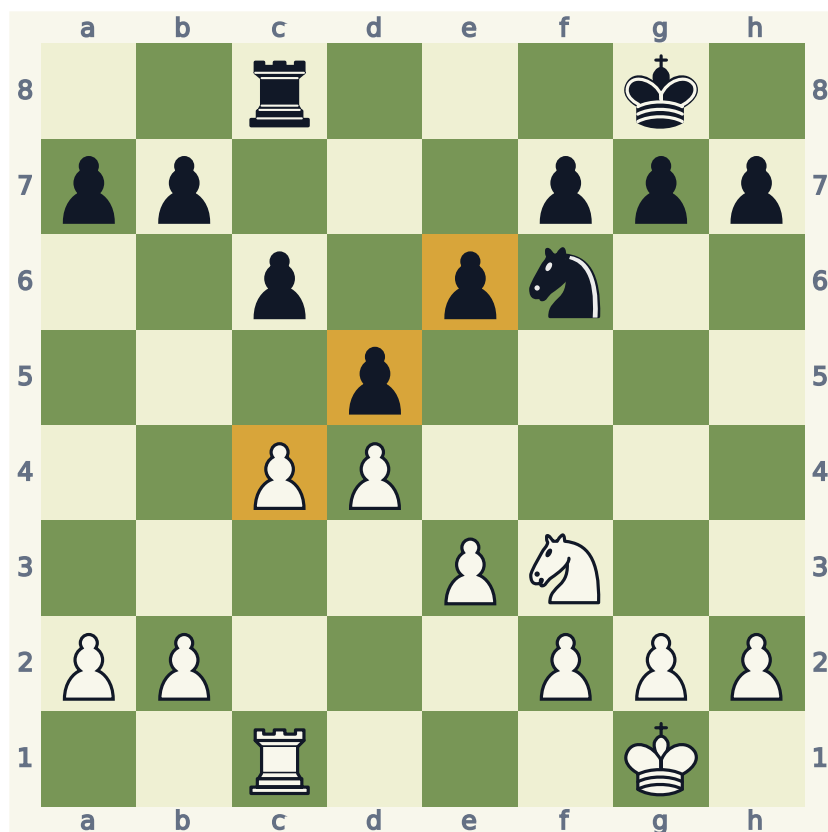


Pawn tension and timing

Keep useful choices; release tension for a reason.

Pawn tension exists when opposing pawns can capture each other. Keeping it preserves choices and may restrict the opponent. Releasing it can win time, create a target or open a useful line. Compare capture, advance and maintain; choose according to the resulting piece activity and pawn structure.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- White's c4-pawn and Black's d5-pawn are in contact.
- Black can recapture with the e6-pawn.
- The exchange opens the c-file only as far as Black's c6-pawn.

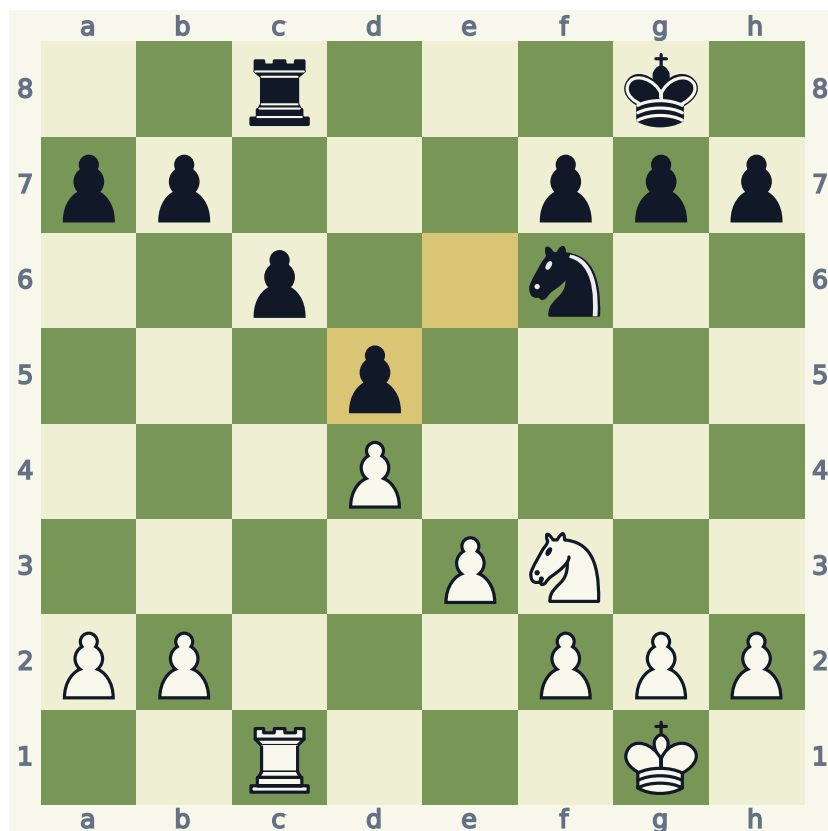
REMEMBER

- Compare capture, advance and maintain.
- Identify every plausible recapturing piece.
- Do not trade useful tension for enemy activity.

Follow the logic

1. cxd5 exd5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



cxd5

White commits to a structure. The move is useful only if the new targets or piece routes are worth giving up the tension.

...exd5

Black keeps a pawn on d5 and creates the c6-d5 chain. White now has a semi-open c-file against c6.

New plan

Prepare pressure on c6 or a queenside minority attack. Black gets access to the semi-open e-file and central activity.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black may prefer to resolve the tension first with ...dxc4 in other positions. Both sides should ask who benefits from each recapture and whether an intermediate move changes the order.

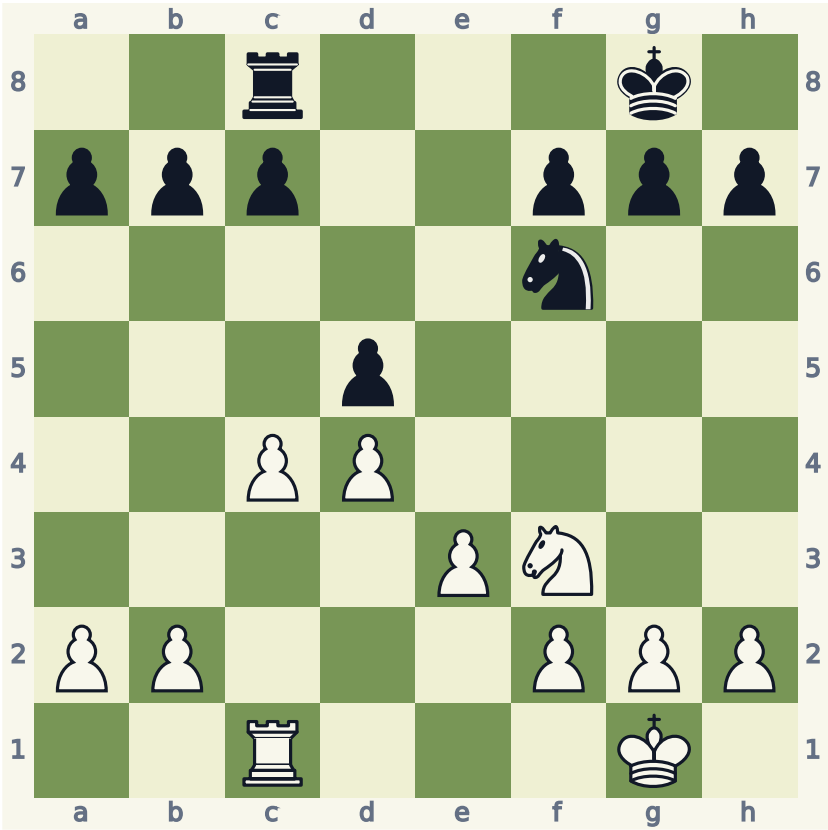
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not capture just because it is available. A capture can solve the opponent's development problem or give a rook an open file without creating a meaningful target for you.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. How does removing Black's e-pawn change the recapture?
- 2. Compare the black knight before and after the exchange.
- 3. What must justify cxd5 in this version?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

What if e3-e4 could safely attack the knight on d5 immediately?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 2r3k1/ppp2ppp/5n2/3p4/2PP4/4PN2/PP3PPP/2R3K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. There is no e6-pawn to recapture. In the sample line Black recaptures with Nf6. The same white pawn move now leads to a different kind of position.
2. The knight becomes centralized on d5. White has removed the d5-pawn, but has helped an enemy piece occupy the center. White cannot describe this simply as creating a weak pawn.
3. White needs a concrete benefit: a useful file, a later e4 advance that gains time, or a favorable tactical sequence. Without one, maintaining the tension deserves serious consideration.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. cxd5 Nxd5

Changed feature: Then the centralization might be temporary. Calculate the pawn advance and the knight's retreat before deciding whether the exchange helps Black.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

For five pawn captures in your games, reconstruct the position one move earlier and explain what keeping the tension would have preserved.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 05, 15, 17. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.